VII—Legend

‘’Tis not the chain of insanity on the neck of the afflicted Majnun
Love hath laid a loving hand on his neck.’

– A verse by Akbar, quoted in the *Akbarnama*

Akbar was a few weeks short of twenty-seven years old when Salim was born, in August 1569. A little late in the day, perhaps, for an emperor of fourteen years’ standing to produce his first child and heir.

There had been children born or conceived over the years. Hasan and Husain who died in infancy five years previously, and others too, perhaps. Abul Fazl mentions ‘various stories’[1] circulating in the city; and a later visitor to Akbar’s court, the Jesuit Father Monserrate, relates one of them. Just before Akbar left on his first campaign against Ali Quli, in 1565, the padishah had given orders for the old, brick-built citadel in Agra to be torn down – it had ‘become ruinous’, writes Nizamuddin[2] – and replaced by a grand monument of red stone. Its walls, 2.5 metres thick, were to rise 50 sheer metres into the air, towering, as they do even today, over visitors squinting up at their heights from the streets below. As this grand fortress was being built – it took eight years, at least, to complete – a rumour spread that it was ‘overrun with ghosts, which rushed to and fro’ destroying the emperor’s belongings, terrifying his harem, and murdering his newborn children.[3]

It wasn’t enough any more for God to offer his opinions on Akbar’s policies via the emperor’s elephant rides; now, Akbar needed His active aid. A child is the only thing, according to Abul Fazl, that Akbar ever prayed for,[4] and he did it in his usual comprehensive style, rallying ‘dervishes, ascetics and theologians’ to his cause, as if rousing soldiers to battle. Finally, and famously, one of them succeeded in his plea – Shaikh Salim of the same Chishti order as Ajmer’s Moinuddin. As the Rajput kingdoms had fallen, so now sons were born ‘one after another’: Salim in 1569, Murad the year after, and Daniyal in 1572.

In gratitude, as it is often said, Akbar ordered his best-known architectural project: a whole new city in the small village outside Agra where Shaikh Salim lived, a grand affair of ‘great size and magnificent appearance’[5] –